Marrowdeep — Story Bible & Storyboard v2

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Summary

Marrowdeep becomes a three-act revenge story: an exiled prince walks home across the marshes (Act I), fights through his own fallen city to the palace gate (Act II), is dropped into Hell, and climbs back up through the crypts to kill his brother, the King (Act III). Each act has five regions and five bosses: 15 in all.

- **Spine:** your friend's story (the brothers, the devil's pact, the murdered father, the frame, the pikes, the bridge). Your betrayal details fill the gaps: how his name is destroyed, why he's exiled, how the city goes dark, the wife taken.
- **One recommended change to both versions:** the wife is *not* on the pike. The children are dead; the third body is a servant in her dress. Ilse is alive in the palace, and her candle is what keeps calling him up out of Hell. This keeps the existing ending ("She lit it from hers") and the Saint's line ("Someone keeps calling you up"), and gives Act III a reason beyond revenge. It's flagged as a decision below, with your friend's version as Option A.
- **Reuse:** all five existing bosses survive in new places. The Tithe-Collector and the Choir move into the city (Act II); the Weeping Mother and the Saint stay in the Deep (Act III); Count Varhollow becomes the brother, King Cassian Varhollow. That leaves **10 new bosses**, not 15.
- **Storyboard:** 88 panels with ids, ratios, prompts and caption text, in the same pipeline as the current stills. 21 existing stills can be kept or lightly redone.

I read "3 stages to get to the last stage" as three acts, with the King at the end of Act III. If you meant three acts *plus* a separate final stage, say so and the castle becomes its own act.

All names below (Halden, Cassian, Aldous, Tomas, Wren, the generals) are placeholders. Change any of them freely.

Cast

Every major character wants something specific and is hiding something; that's what makes a scene between two of them worth writing.

Character	Who	Wants	Wound / secret
Halden (the player)	Elder prince, first sword of the realm, the father's favourite. After exile: the hooded man.	To get his family back; later, to make his brother answer.	His temper. He did threaten Cassian once, in front of the court. That's why the frame was believable. He died on the bridge and doesn't know it until Act III.
Cassian Varhollow (the brother, final boss)	Younger prince. Fought beside Halden in every war; did the work their father wouldn't put his name to.	The crown, and to be *seen* by his father, once.	He burned Kesh on the King's order and Halden got the songs. He sold his soul and the soul of every man who swears to him to the Hungry One. "I did the arithmetic. It balanced. I forgot to count myself."
King Aldous (the father, boss 14)	Old king, dying slowly, a great general once.	A clean succession; to be remembered well.	He gave the order to burn Kesh and let Cassian carry it. He favoured one son in public and never noticed what it did to the other. Murdered by Cassian with Halden's sword.

Character	Who	Wants	Wound / secret
Ilse (the wife)	Halden's wife. Clever, stubborn, keeps a candle in the window when he's at war.	Her children alive; then, to keep Halden from being lost.	Taken into the palace as Cassian's "queen" after the exile. What happens there is never shown. Her candle is what calls Halden up out of the Deep. Her last letter ("Come home") was written with Cassian watching.
Tomas (son, 9) and **Wren** (daughter, 6)	Halden's children. Tomas carries a wooden horse Halden carved; Wren copies her mother's candle.	Their father home.	Killed by Cassian to break Halden. Never shown dying. Their souls are in Agathe's cradle in the Deep (boss 11).
The Hungry One 餓 (the devil)	The thing at the bottom of the Marrowdeep. Its face is the Hungry Altar in the Rope-House; its eye is the red Wound in the sky.	Oaths. Every soul sworn to Cassian is owed to it.	Its contract only holds while the crown is uncontested. A living rightful heir makes every oath half-owed. That's why Cassian needs Halden dead, and why he lured him home.
Oswin Rook (the Iron Marshal, boss 9)	Halden's oldest friend, commander of the cavalry.	To keep his own family safe.	He saw Cassian leave the King's chamber that night and said nothing at the trial.
Piet (boss 5)	Halden's former shield-bearer, now captain of the border fort.	To do his duty to the crown.	Believes the frame completely. He's the first to tell Halden what happened to Ilse.

Character	Who	Wants	Wound / secret
Agathe (the Weeping Mother)	The midwife who delivered Tomas and Wren. Dead, in the Deep.	To keep the children she delivered from the dark.	Holds the souls of the dead children of Hollowmere, Halden's two among them.
Saint Aurel (Saint Without Skin)	A martyr burned in the Kiln.	To be let go.	Tells Halden he is dead.
Ser Gideon Vale (the King's Hand, boss 10)	Cassian's champion, the Red Knight.	Rank.	Holds the bridge. Lights the charges.

The hood: at the trial Halden is stripped of his colours and given a convict's black hooded cloak for the road. He never takes it off. That's the dark hooded figure the player already sees.

The story

The story runs prologue → three acts → ending, and every act ends on a turn that makes the next one necessary.

Prologue: the Last War and the Betrayal

1. **The walls of Kesh** (playable, replaces the Hollowmere Wall tutorial). Halden and Cassian storm the enemy fortress side by side. Cassian fights next to you as an NPC; the chalk lessons stay. At the end the King's rider brings an order: burn the granaries. Halden refuses to. Cassian does it without a word.
2. **The triumph.** Hollowmere's gates open. The crowd chants Halden's name. Cassian rides behind him, unnoticed. That night the King names Halden heir before the court. Halden, drunk and proud, tells Cassian in front of everyone that he'll "find a use for him." (His flaw; it will be used against him.)
3. **The pact.** Cassian goes down alone into the old crypt under the palace, to the stone face with seven bleeding eyes. The Hungry One names its price: Cassian's soul, and the soul of every man who swears to him.
4. **Poisoning a name** (one page of quick panels). Weeks of rumour. Letters to Kesh in Halden's hand, forged. A lord says Halden laughed at the King's cough. The generals start to look at him differently.

5. **The night.** Halden drinks wine Cassian poured. He wakes on the floor of the King's chamber holding his own sword. The King is dead. Cassian is in the doorway with the guard, and he looks heartbroken.
6. **The trial.** The generals testify one by one. Rook says nothing. The crowd wants Halden hanged. Cassian begs the court for mercy: exile, not death. The crowd loves him for it. Halden's wife and children will stay "under the crown's protection." Halden understands they are hostages, and that staying means they die.
7. **Farewell.** Ilse at the window, the children on the stairs. She presses a candle stub into his hand: "Bring it back lit." Tomas gives him the wooden horse. Stripped of his colours, in the convict's hood, he rides out.
8. **The coronation** (he doesn't see it; we do). Cassian is crowned in the cathedral. The Choir sings. The sky opens a red eye.

Act I: The Road Home (the March)

Months later, far away. A crow lands with a letter from Ilse: *"He comes to the house now. The children ask for you. Come home."* That's the act's goal: get home.

- The way back crosses the March: fens, the gallows road, a war camp, a burned village, the border fort.
- Along the way the player learns, region by region, what's become of the kingdom. The fen hags read his fate ("you'll come home to a gate of pikes"). The Hound-Warden carries a royal warrant: *The Kingslayer, alive or dead.* The Hollowed Legion are his own old soldiers with black eyes; they don't flinch, they don't sleep. A burned village has turned to a new faith in the King. A second letter: *"They took the tithe in our street. One in ten."*
- A third crow comes with no letter, only blood on its leg.
- **Act turn:** at the border fort Piet, his old shield-bearer, fights him as the Kingslayer. Dying, Piet tells him the truth as Piet believes it: "The King took your wife into the palace. She doesn't come to the window any more." (This is the only telling of what happened to Ilse. Nothing more is ever said or shown.)

Act II: Hollowmere in Darkness

The city has sealed itself. Halden comes home to fear: curfew bells, the soul tithe, hymns rewritten for the new King, Hollowed guards at every corner.

- He fights through the siege works (General Brann), the lower city where the Tithe-Collector takes one soul in ten, and the cathedral where the Choir of Teeth sang at the coronation.
- **The truth:** Marshal Rook, his oldest friend, fights him at the barracks and, beaten, confesses: he saw Cassian leave the King's chamber that night and kept quiet to protect his own children. Now Halden knows. Optional: Rook's dying line names the pact ("he swore us all to something under the palace").
- **The gate of pikes.** At the palace bridge Halden sees three shapes on pikes over the gate, small against a red sky. A wooden horse lies on the cobbles. A broken candle. He can't see faces from there; he doesn't need to.
- He charges. Ser Gideon Vale, the King's Hand, holds the bridge (boss 10). Beaten, Gideon smiles and drops his torch. Cassian watches from the balcony. The bridge goes up under Halden, and he falls into the Marrowdeep.

Act III: The Marrowdeep, and the Climb

"You fell." (The current Act I opening panels fit here almost unchanged.) He wakes among bones. This is Hell, and from here it looks like it: red, burning, crowded with the damned.

- **The cradle** (boss 11, the Weeping Mother). Agathe, who delivered his children, rocks a cradle of small lights. Two of them are Tomas and Wren. Beating her is letting them go: "Let them go, Agathe." The lights rise. This is where the children's story ends, quietly, instead of on the pike.
- **The Gaoler of the Sold** (boss 12). A prison of cages holding the souls of Cassian's Legion, everyone who swore. Breaking the Gaoler's keys frees them; up in the palace, the Hollowed start to fall.
- **The Kiln** (boss 13, Saint Without Skin). Aurel tells him: "You died on the bridge, child. Someone keeps calling you up." He looks at the candle stub. It's still warm.
- He realises the third body on the pike was not Ilse. She's alive, and she has never stopped lighting the candle.
- **The crypts and sewers** under the palace. In the royal crypt, the Dead King (boss 14), his father, bound by the pact, fights him as the son who murdered him. Beaten and freed, Aldous sees the truth: "Then I named the right son. And I made the other one."
- **The throne room** (boss 15). King Cassian, the crown with a hole in it, Ilse at his side in silence. Phase 3: the Wound in the sky opens through him. At the end the Hungry One offers Halden the same bargain: his life back, the crown, his wife, for his soul. Ilse lifts her candle. He refuses.

- **The finisher** stays: 止め. Cassian's last line: "I did the arithmetic. It balanced. I forgot to count myself."

Ending: dawn

Dawn comes up grey over Hollowmere. The Hollowed are just men again, confused, kneeling in the streets. Halden stands in his own doorway. Ilse lights his stub from hers. She knows what he is; she lights it anyway. As the sun comes up he grows faint. The last panel: two candles in the window.

"Go back down" (the descent loop) is now motivated: the Hungry One still holds the souls of the Hollowmere dead it took before the pact was broken. Each tier is another descent to bring more of them up. The Rope-House becomes his house on the edge of the Deep, with Ilse at the window.

Editor's challenges

The weakest point in both drafts is the same: a hero who flees and leaves his wife and children reads as a coward unless the story makes running the only way to keep them alive. The rest are listed by how much they'd hurt the book if left alone; each has a proposed fix, already written into the story above where marked ✓.

1. **Why does the greatest warrior in the kingdom run?** ✓ He doesn't run; he's *sentenced* to exile, and Cassian's "mercy" keeps the family as surety. Staying means they die. If he's simply chased off on horseback, readers will ask why he didn't take them.
2. **Why frame him instead of just killing him?** A dead heir starts a civil war; a disgraced one hands the crown over willingly. ✓ The devil's terms need oaths sworn freely, so Cassian needs the people to *choose* him. That also makes the frame the engine of the whole plot instead of a cruelty.
3. **Envy alone makes a cardboard villain.** ✓ Give Cassian a real grievance: he did the father's dirty work (Kesh) and the brother got the songs. Readers should half-understand him by the throne room. The Count's existing line ("I forgot to count myself") only lands if he's been keeping score all along.
4. **A perfect hero can't be framed believably.** ✓ Halden's temper and pride: he publicly humiliates Cassian on the night he's named heir. The frame works because people already half-believe it.

5. **Why kill the children?** Cruelty with no purpose turns a villain into a cartoon. ✓ Cassian needs Halden to come home and die, because a living rightful heir keeps the pact half-paid. The letter that says "come home" was written with Cassian watching; the pikes are bait for the bridge. Decide whether the player learns this from Rook (Act II) or from Cassian himself (throne room). I'd save it for the throne room.
6. **The assault on Ilse.** Implied-not-shown is the right instinct, and the doc keeps it to one spoken line and her silence. The risk is a well-known one: a wife who suffers only to motivate the hero reads as a prop. If she's in the story, she needs her own thread and a choice that matters. ✓ Option B gives her the candle, the letters, and the moment she lifts the candle against the devil's offer. If she won't get that, consider cutting the assault: the pikes already carry Act II's rage. Either way it goes on Steam's mature content survey.
7. **Option A or B: is Ilse on the pike?** Your friend's version kills all three. That's a cleaner revenge story, but then Act III is revenge with nothing to save, the ending's candle panels need a different owner, and the Rope-House loses Ilse. Option B (recommended) keeps the horror at the gate and pays it off: the third body is a servant in her dress, and Halden learns the truth in the Kiln. **Decision needed.**
8. **Show the children's deaths, or not?** ✓ Not. Aftermath only: shapes on pikes too far to see faces, a wooden horse on the cobbles. It's more frightening, it's how good horror handles it, and image generators won't produce the explicit version anyway.
9. **Revenge has to cost the avenger.** ✓ He's already dead. He wins and can't stay. That's the ending's price, and it's already seeded by the Saint's existing line.
10. **Why can a dead man climb out of Hell?** ✓ The candle. Ilse keeps lighting it; "someone keeps calling you up." The Act I stub that won't light becomes the clue.
11. **"The castle goes evil" needs to be specific, not a red filter.** ✓ Each Act II region shows one concrete change: sealed gates, the soul tithe, rewritten hymns, generals who obey without blinking, heads over the palace gate. Letters in Act I show it starting.
12. **Five generals with one motive blur together.** ✓ Give each a different reason: Brann (fear), the Tithe-Collector (greed), the Choir (faith), Rook (guilt, protecting his own children), Gideon (ambition).
13. **Does the player know Cassian is guilty from the start?** Showing the pact in the prologue gives dread (the player knows, Halden doesn't). Hiding it gives a mystery Rook solves in Act II. I'd show it: this is a tragedy, not a whodunit, and the player playing beside Cassian in the tutorial makes the betrayal hurt. **Decision needed.**

14. **The father shouldn't be a saint.** ✓ He ordered Kesh burned and let Cassian carry it; he favoured one son openly. Meeting him in the crypt is about his guilt as much as Halden's grief.
15. **The Japanese-gothic blend** (kanji epigraphs, vows, 止め) with European names needs one in-world reason or a confident shrug. Option: Hollowmere's faith came from the east with Halden's mother's family. Small, but readers notice.
16. **Ilse moves from sister to wife.** Every existing line about her ("Bring it back lit", the cough, the window) still works for a wife. The cough can stay as a reason she can't flee the city. Existing stills of a 19-year-old girl need redoing as a woman in her late twenties.

Game structure

The game becomes 3 acts × 5 regions; each region is one dungeon level plus a boss level for the first build (31 maps with the prologue, up from about 11), with a second level per region added later if the acts feel short.

Regions and bosses

#	Region	Environment (look)	Boss	Boss idea	Story beat
P	The Walls of Kesh	war (reuse surface)	—	Tutorial beside Cassian	The brothers; the granaries burn
1	The Rushmere Fen	**marsh**: black water, reeds, hanging moss, stilt huts, fog	The Three Sisters of the Fen	Three hags share one life bar; they swap places through the water; kill order matters	They read his fate: a gate of pikes
2	The Gallows Road	**forest**: dead pines, gibbets, rain, a muddy road	Ser Odo Gallowmark, the Hound-Warden	Mounted charges, releases his hounds in waves, nets you	Royal warrant: the Kingslayer
3	The Black Camp	**war camp**: palisades, tents, banners, pyres	Captain Merrow, the First Hollowed	A shield-wall boss with a squad that moves as one; doesn't flinch, doesn't stagger until his men fall	His own soldiers, with black eyes

#	Region	Environment (look)	Boss	Boss idea	Story beat
4	Saint Edda's Ashes	**burned village**: charred houses, a smoking chapel, gallows tree	The Lantern Preacher	Throws oil, sets the floor alight, his congregation shields him	A new faith in the new King; second letter
5	The Last Light (border fort)	**fort**: stone walls, ballistae, snow	Piet, the Shield-Bearer	Halden's own old fighting style mirrored: parries, rolls, a tower shield	"The King took your wife."
6	The Siege Works	**city walls**: earthworks, trebuchets, sealed gates	General Brann the Mortar	Calls bombardments on marked ground, engineers lay mines	The city sealed itself in
7	The Lower City	**debt** (reuse): slums, gallows, cages, tithe-carts	The Tithe-Collector ♻	Existing fight; Debt Anchors stay	One soul in ten
8	The Cathedral of the Crown	**chapel** (reuse water env, flooded nave)	The Choir of Teeth ♻	Existing fight; the Hymn phase now sings the coronation hymn	Where Cassian was crowned
9	The Iron Barracks	**barracks**: parade ground, stables, forges	Marshal Oswin Rook	Cavalry charges across the ground, then fights on foot when unhorsed	The confession
10	The Palace Bridge	**bridge**: long span, statues, the gate of pikes	Ser Gideon Vale, the King's Hand	A fight on a narrowing bridge; sections fall; ends in the scripted fall	The pikes; the bridge blown
11	The Ossuary	**bone**, red-graded (reuse)	The Weeping Mother ♻	Existing fight; the Lullaby phase uses the children's voices	The children let go
12	The Sold Gaol	**hell prison**: cages over a lava sea, chains, soul-lanterns	The Gaoler of the Sold	Swings cages on chains; each broken key frees souls that fight beside you briefly	The Legion's souls freed
13	The Kiln of Saints	**fire** (reuse), hotter	Saint Without Skin ♻	Existing fight	"You died on the bridge."

#	Region	Environment (look)	Boss	Boss idea	Story beat
14	The Royal Crypt	**crypt + sewers**: tombs, drains, rats, royal effigies	The Dead King	His sword style is yours (he taught you); chained to his tomb, the chains break as he weakens	"Then I named the right son."
15	The Throne Room	**castle**: black banners, a cracked throne, the Wound through the roof	King Cassian Varhollow ♻ (reworked Count)	Existing 3 phases kept: the iai duel becomes the brothers' last duel; phase 3 is the Wound	The pact, the offer, the candle

♻ = existing boss reused, art and lines updated. New: 10 bosses.

New monsters by act

Each act gets 6–8 new foes plus reskins of existing ones, so every act looks and plays differently.

Act	New foes	Reused (reskinned)
I The March	Fen Hag (curse puddles, blinks between pools) · Bog Drowner (grabs from the water) · Marsh Lantern (wisp that lures you toward bogs) · Bounty Rider (mounted charge) · Hollowed Footman (shield, never flinches) · Hollowed Pikeman (long reach, sets against charges) · Lantern Zealot (oil flasks, fire) · Scarecrow (stands still until you pass)	Gutter Hound → warhounds · Carrion Swarm → gallows crows · Penitent → villagers · Archers
II Hollowmere	Hollowed Guard and Halberdier · Tithe-Taker (chain grapple, drags you) · Curfew Bellman (rings a bell that summons a wave) · Plague Doctor (rot clouds) · Siege Engineer (bombs) · Rooftop Gargoyle · Knight of the Hand (heavy elite)	Ceiling Leech → sewer leech · Candle Nun → choir acolyte · Gilded Debtor stays · hanged debtors stay

Act	New foes	Reused (reskinned)
III The Deep → the palace	The Damned (crawling hordes) · Brimstone Imp (flies, fireballs) · Chain Demon (hooks you in) · Lava Wretch (rises from lava) · Turnkey (gaol guards with keys) · Ember Hound · Sewer Ghoul · Rat Swarm · Crypt Knight (royal guard, dead)	Flayed Knight · bloats · Bone Kings' dead · wraiths · Wall-Born

Look per act

- **Act I:** cold and grey-green under a white sky; rain, fog, mud; the red Wound faint on the horizon, growing as you get closer to home.
- **Act II:** night city; torchlight, black banners, red only from the sky and the tithe-lanterns.
- **Act III:** Hell is red and orange, fire everywhere, ash falling upward. The crypts and sewers are the first blue-black cold after it, a relief that tells the player they're climbing out. The throne room is black and gold under the open Wound.

Systems that change

- **Monster levels:** the current curve (1 + 2 × depth on Pilgrim) assumes about 11 levels. With 31 it needs spreading so Pilgrim still ends around 21.
- **The map** (cross-section): becomes a journey: the March across the surface, Hollowmere, the bridge, the long fall, and the climb back up under the palace.
- **Old saves:** a character mid-campaign needs mapping from the old 5 acts to a sensible new region (or restarting the campaign while keeping gear and level).
- **Remembrance stones, Codex, epigraphs, boss farewells, Ilse's letters:** all rewritten for the new story. The 28 Codex entries roughly double.

Storyboard

The new story needs 94 manga panels: 65 new, 22 existing stills kept as they are, and 7 existing stills redone (mostly Ilse, now a wife rather than a teenage sister). Each act opener and each boss's first "fall" panel stays a live shot of the level, as now.

How to use it: generate a still for an id, name the file exactly `<id>.png`, and drop it in a session; it goes into `art/manga/` and the manifest. Captions are the text the game prints over the panel, not part of the image. ♻ keep = existing still reused under a new id; ♻ redo = same composition, regenerate with the new character.

Style header (prepend to every prompt)

> 1-bit pixel-art manga panel with chunky square pixels, only four colours: black ink #0e0a0a, off-white paper #ece6d8, blood red #b0141a, and a darker red for shadows in red areas. Heavy black shadows, dithered mid-tones, seinen dark fantasy, medieval kingdom, Japanese horror mood. Bold, high-contrast shapes. No text, no letters, no speech bubbles, no border.

Keep red for blood, fire, the Wound and candle flames only, so it stays meaningful. Generate a little wider than the ratio; the game crops the centre. Violence is always shown by aftermath or silhouette, never wounds.

Character sheets (make these first, use as references)

Sheet	Description
`ref-halden`	Man in his early thirties, broad, gaunt from the road, short dark hair, stubble, scar through one eyebrow, hard tired eyes. Prologue: polished royal armour with a white surcoat. After exile: ragged black hooded convict's cloak over battered mail, a plain longsword. Never smiles after the prologue.
`ref-cassian`	His younger brother, late twenties, leaner, fair hair tied back, clean-shaven, handsome, a careful gentle face that smiles too easily. Dark fine armour. As King: black and gold robes, a hollow iron crown with a dark opening in it.
`ref-aldous`	Old king, sixties, white beard, heavy and ill, a great general once. As the Dead King: grey skin, hollow eyes, chains, the same crown.

Sheet	Description
`ref-ilse`	Woman in her late twenties, thin and pale, long straight dark hair, dark wool shawl over a plain dress, clever stubborn eyes, always with a small candle. In the palace: a black court dress, hair pinned up, very still.
`ref-children`	Tomas, a boy of nine, dark hair like his father, holding a carved wooden horse. Wren, a girl of six, copying her mother with a tiny candle.
`ref-hungry-one`	A vast stone face set in a crypt wall, seven eyes weeping blood, mouth an open pit; in the sky, a colossal red eye-shaped wound.
`ref-generals`	Rook: grey-bearded cavalry marshal, heavy plate, a horsehair plume. Piet: young soldier, earnest face, tower shield. Gideon: tall knight in red-lacquered plate, a smile. Brann: thick-necked engineer-general, soot and sweat.
`ref-act1-foes`	The fen sisters (three crooked hags, one with no eyes, one with no mouth, one with too many fingers). Ser Odo (hunter in a bear-skin over mail, on a black horse, hounds). Captain Merrow (soldier with fully black eyes). The Lantern Preacher (gaunt priest with a raised lantern).
Existing	Agathe, Saint Aurel, the Choir, the Tithe-Collector: as in `higgsfield-shots.md`.

Recurring props, keep them identical across panels: the candle stub, Tomas's wooden horse, the crow, the hollow crown, the red Wound.

Prologue: the Last War and the Betrayal

id	ratio	prompt (after the style header)	caption
pr-01-kesh	21:9	Two armoured knights on a breached fortress wall at night, fire behind, banners torn, an army pouring through the gap	Kesh fell in a single night.
pr-02-backs	16:9	Halden and Cassian back to back, swords raised, enemies all around, both grinning	Side by side. As always.
pr-03-order	16:9	A rider handing a wax-sealed order to Cassian; Halden behind him turning away	The King's order: burn the granaries.
pr-04-granary	21:9	Cassian alone in silhouette before huge burning granaries, tiny figures fleeing	Cassian did it. No one sang about it.
pr-05-triumph	21:9	Halden riding through a cheering crowd under falling petals, Cassian a step behind him in shadow	They chanted one name.
pr-06-heir	16:9	The old King on his throne, hand on Halden's shoulder, the court kneeling, Cassian at the far edge	"My heir."
pr-07-insult	1:1	Halden laughing with a raised cup, looking down at someone	"I'll find a use for you, brother."
pr-08-crypt	4:5	Cassian descending a spiral stone stair with a torch into darkness	Under the palace there is an older door.
pr-09-altar	21:9	A vast stone face with seven bleeding eyes set in a crypt wall, candles below, Cassian kneeling, tiny	Something down there was hungry.
pr-10-price	16:9	Cassian's cut palm held over the stone face's open mouth, blood dripping in	His soul. And the soul of every man who swears to him.

id	ratio	prompt (after the style header)	caption
pr-11-letters	16:9	A hand copying Halden's signature and seal by candlelight, a stack of forged letters	Letters to Kesh, in your hand.
pr-12-wine	1:1	Cassian pouring dark wine into Halden's cup, smiling warmly	"Drink with me, brother."
pr-13-wake	21:9	Halden waking on the floor of a royal bedchamber, a sword in his hand, an old man's limp hand hanging from the bed	You woke with your sword in your hand.
pr-14-doorway	4:5	Cassian in a doorway with torch-bearing guards, his face breaking with grief	"Brother… what have you done?"
pr-15-trial	21:9	Halden in chains in a great hall, generals standing one by one to accuse him, a crowd in the galleries	The generals spoke, one by one.
pr-16-rook	1:1	Rook, grey-bearded, looking away, jaw clenched	Rook said nothing.
pr-17-mercy	16:9	Cassian kneeling before the court with hands open, pleading, the crowd moved	"Not death. Exile. He is still my brother."
pr-18-hostage	16:9	Ilse and two small children behind a line of halberds, guards around them	"Your family will stay. Under the crown's protection."
pr-19-window	16:9	♻ redo `op-2-window` with Ilse: a lit candle on a dark window sill, a woman's silhouette beside it, rooftops	One window still lit.
pr-20-candle	16:9	♻ redo `op-3-candle`: a woman's thin hand pressing a lit candle stub into a man's gauntleted hand	"Bring it back lit."
pr-21-horse	1:1	A small boy's hands holding up a carved wooden horse	"So you're not alone."

id	ratio	prompt (after the style header)	caption
pr-22-hood	16:9	Halden's white surcoat torn from his shoulders, a black hooded cloak thrown at him	They took your colours.
pr-23-ride	21:9	A hooded rider leaving a city gate at dawn, the walls behind, a crow overhead	You rode out with a candle and a wooden horse.
pr-24-crowned	21:9	Cassian crowned in a cathedral, a hollow iron crown lowered onto his head, choir in rows	They crowned him in a week.
pr-25-eye	21:9	♻ redo `op-6-count` with Cassian: the new King on the wall raising the hollow crown, a red eye opening in the clouds	That night the sky opened an eye.

Act I: The Road Home

id	ratio	prompt	caption
a1-01-exile	21:9	A hooded man alone by a small fire in a frozen far-off wilderness, his horse behind him	Far away. Months later.
a1-02-crow	21:9	♻ keep `op-5-crow`	A crow found you.
a1-03-letter	16:9	♻ keep `a2-3-letter`	"He comes to the house now. The children ask for you. Come home."
a1-04-road	21:9	The hooded rider on a long muddy road, a faint red eye-wound low on the far horizon	Home.
b01-2-sisters	21:9	Three crooked hags in fog around black water, one eyeless, one mouthless, one with too many fingers, casting bones	"You'll come home to a gate of pikes."

id	ratio	prompt	caption
b01-3-sink	16:9	The three hags sinking back into black water, only hands left above it	The fen took them back.
b02-2-warrant	16:9	A crude wanted drawing of a hooded man nailed to a gibbet in the rain, a crossed-out crown under it, no legible words	"The Kingslayer. Alive or dead."
b02-3-hounds	16:9	Hounds lying down around their fallen master in the mud, one licking his hand	His hounds wouldn't leave him.
b03-2-eyes	1:1	Close-up of a young soldier's face, eyes completely black, rain on his helmet	"You trained me, Captain."
b03-3-still	16:9	Rows of soldiers standing perfectly still in the rain around their fallen captain, not looking down	His men didn't even blink.
a1-05-tithe	16:9	A night street, a cart of shrouded shapes, a painted mark on every tenth door	"They took the tithe in our street. One in ten."
b04-2-preacher	4:5	A gaunt priest raising a lantern before a burning chapel, villagers kneeling around him	"The new King hears every prayer."
b04-3-lantern	16:9	A broken lantern in grey ash, the chapel smoking behind	He heard nothing.
a1-06-crow	1:1	A crow on a post, an empty thread on its leg, red on its foot	The third crow brought no letter.
b05-2-piet	16:9	A young soldier sitting against a snowy fort wall, wounded, tower shield beside him, the hooded man standing over him	"The King took your wife into the palace."
b05-3-window	16:9	A tall palace window at night, dark, no candle	"She doesn't come to the window any more."

Act II: Hollowmere in Darkness

id	ratio	prompt	caption
a2-01-sealed	21:9	A great city's gates bricked up, black banners on the walls, the red eye-wound above	Hollowmere had shut its gates.
a2-02-curfew	16:9	An empty street at night, a hunched bellman ringing a hand bell, shutters closing	One bell for curfew. One for the tithe.
b06-2-brann	16:9	A sweating general over a siege map, two small girls' portraits pinned beside it	"He'd have my daughters if I opened that gate."
b07-2-ledger	21:9	♻ keep `a3-2-ledger`	The tithe: one soul in ten.
b07-3-names	21:9	♻ redo `a3-4-ilse`: a ledger page, three names together, two struck through in wet red ink	Your household. Two names already paid.
b07-4-cage	16:9	♻ keep `b3-2-cage`	The debtors climb out, still holding out their coins.
b08-2-mouths	16:9	♻ keep `b2-2-mouths`	"…long live the King, long live the King…"
b08-3-shut	16:9	♻ keep `b2-4-shut`	Silence is also a note.
b09-2-rook	16:9	An old cavalry marshal unhorsed and kneeling, helmet off, his horse dead behind him	"I saw him leave the King's chamber."
b09-3-hostages	16:9	Memory: two children standing stiffly, a fair-haired man's gloved hands resting on their heads	"He has my children too."
b09-4-under	1:1	The marshal's eyes closing, a single tear	"He swore us all to something under the palace."

id	ratio	prompt	caption
a2-03-gate	21:9	A long bridge to a palace gate at night; above the gate, three small dark shapes on tall pikes against a red sky, too far to make out	The palace gate. Something hung above it.
a2-04-horse	1:1	A carved wooden toy horse on wet cobbles, a broken candle beside it	Tomas's horse.
a2-05-eyes	1:1	Extreme close-up of the hooded man's eyes, tears, rage	(sound effect 怒)
a2-06-charge	21:9	The hooded man charging alone across the bridge, sword out, speed lines, guards ahead	(no caption)
b10-2-torch	16:9	A knight in red armour on his knees, smiling, letting a torch fall onto a line of powder kegs	"The King sends his regards."
b10-3-balcony	4:5	The young King on a high balcony, crown on, watching, face unreadable	He watched from the balcony.
b10-4-blast	21:9	The bridge exploding beneath a tiny figure, stone breaking apart	(sound effect 轟)
a2-07-fall	21:9	♻ keep `a1-1-fall`	You fell.